time planning became a constitutional excercise at any level i.e. at the panchayat level.

Though the planning at the central and the state levels are still extra-constitutional activities, it has become constitutional at the local bodies level. Kerala has shown some pathbreaking good works via local body planning.[93] But still there are many hurdles to be solved before the local bodies are really able to plan for their proper development. These hurdles as per the experts are as under:

(i) The financial status of the PRIs is still not stabilised.

(ii) Which taxes the PRIs can impose are still not clear

(iii) The state Assemblies have been procrastinating in delegating timely and needful powers to the PRIs.

(iv) Low level of awareness among the local people regarding their Right to Information and the right functioning of the PRIs

(v) Use of money and muscle power in the PRI elections in some states

By mid-2002, there took place an all India Panchayat Adhyaksha Sammelan in New Delhi. At the end off the meet, the Panchayat Adhyakshs handed over '21 Point Memorandum' to the Government which specially dealt with the financial status of the PRIs. In July 2002, while the then PM was addressing the annual meet of the District Rural Development Agency (DRDA), he announced that the PRIs will be given 'financial autonomy' very soon. He further added that once there is a political consensus, the Government might go in for a further constitutional Amendment. Unfortunately, the same coalition (i.e. the NDA) did not come to power in the forthcoming General Elections. But the UPA Government does not look less serious on the issue of participatory development. By mid-2006, the Planning Commission wrote letters to every Chief Minister of each state that before the Eleventh Plan commences it wants that all the PRIs are duly delegated their functional powers of planning from the concerned states. Otherwise, the funds kept for local development would not flow to the states. This shows the seriousness of the Central Government.

Once there is a right level of awareness among the local people and the PRIs are able to take their real shape, the planning process will get decentralised, we may be sure of that.